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Community Investment Training: 2027 Application

Deadline: July 10th, 2026

Additional Background Information and Project Narrative

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Secondary Phone Number Type:	Office
Title/Organization:	Executive Director

Project Information

Required **Project Type:** Main Street Revitalization

Required **Project Location (County):** Fayette

Required **Project(s) Summary: Your project summary should be a concise statement that includes key details such as the project objective, desired outcome, problem addressed, and core partners. (Word Count: 100)**

e.g., My project is to restore a vacant property in our downtown to prepare it for sale to a private investor. The property is part of the town's strategic plan for community development. Once renovated, the property would be sold and the income from the sale would be used to work on the next property in the plan. Key partners include the town, chamber of commerce, and a local foundation.

e.g., My project is to increase the amount of available lodging for tourism. Tourism is a large part of our economy, but visitors currently stay in a neighboring county/town. By completing the [Hotel, Inn, Cottages] project, our town will increase its daily occupancy by about [#] rooms. Key partners include the tourism authority, chamber of commerce, and county administration.

e.g., My project is to increase the amount of workforce housing in order to retain/attract workers for our hospital. Health care is a primary employer in our region, but the nurses are not able to afford housing within commuting distance to the hospital. We are working with the hospital, nursing school, and local housing authority to create a mixed-income housing development.

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Required

Harmony for Hope, Inc. is revitalizing two historic Main Street buildings in Mount Hope, WV, held under a 50-year lease. 704 Main Street houses the Fayette County Community Arts Center and will expand into a storefront gallery, conference room, and creative makers space. 708 Main Street will become a restaurant incubator, with its first identified tenant already committed — Patricia Shepard Kelly, whose business, now operating as the Kingston Diner (Pax, WV), has grown through three name changes and continuous expansion. Both buildings anchor the trailhead of the Mount Hope Historic Walking Trail. Core partners include New River Gorge National Park and Preserve, the City of Mount Hope, and WVU.

Project Narrative

Narrative: In **400 words or less**, please describe the project in a way that someone with no familiarity will be able to understand. Please address the prompts below.

a. What is the project?
b. What are the community or economic development needs of the town, community, or people in the project area that are addressed by this project?
c. What industry or economic sector is most related to the project? What role will the project play for that sector?
d. What community asset does the project build upon? What assets, advocates, research, or other resources are critical to the project's success?
e. What are the anticipated challenges? How will you address or mitigate these risks?

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a. What is the project?
The project rehabilitates 704 and 708 Main Street in Mount Hope, WV, buildings Harmony for Hope, Inc. has held under a 50-year lease and maintenance agreement. 704 currently houses the Fayette County Community Arts Center and will expand into a storefront art gallery, conference room, and creative makers space. 708, once stabilized, will become a restaurant incubator anchored by a committed first tenant — a local entrepreneur whose business has operated under three names through continuous growth, now known as the Kingston Diner.
b. What community or economic development needs does this address?
Mount Hope's Main Street has significant vacant and underused historic building stock. There is no existing commercial kitchen or incubator space for food entrepreneurs in the immediate area, and the town's creative economy lacks dedicated gallery, meeting, and makerspace infrastructure. This project converts two vacant/underused floors of historic building stock into active, income-generating community assets.
c. What industry or economic sector is most related?
Tourism and creative-economy small business. The New River Gorge region draws significant visitor traffic; the National Park Service reports the park contributed $94 million to gateway communities in 2024. This project positions Mount Hope to capture more of that visitor spending through food and retail entertainment.
d. What community asset does the project build upon?
The project builds on the Mount Hope Historic Walking Trail, which both buildings physically anchor, and on H4H's decade-plus track record stewarding Main Street cultural infrastructure. Critical resources include an already-completed architectural engineering report, Phase I Environmental Site Assessment, and WV DEP report on 708, plus an identified, committed restaurant tenant.
e. What are the anticipated challenges?
The primary challenge is capital: a structural integrity report ($40,000, firm estimate from New River Engineering, Inc.) is the remaining gating step before a ~$1.5 million stabilization can proceed. A secondary task is surveying and replatting to formally separate the privately-owned adjacent parcel (706 Main Street) from H4H's leasehold, estimated at $8,000–$12,000. These are addressed through a phased funding strategy combining grants, historic tax credit equity, and SBA

Criteria 1: Soundness of Project Approach

1. How will community residents benefit from the project? Will the project result in local ownership? Please address if and how the project will benefit low- and moderate-income residents as part of the response. **(200 Words)**

Required

The buildings remain under nonprofit stewardship throughout — this is not a rehab-and-resell project. Harmony for Hope's 50-year lease keeps the assets in community hands permanently, with no plan to transfer ownership to a private investor. Residents benefit directly: the restaurant incubator at 708 gives a local entrepreneur, already managing a small business in the region that has withstood 3 name changes and constant expansion, her first standalone commercial kitchen space, creating jobs and a new sit-down dining option on Main Street. The arts center expansion at 704 keeps gallery space, meeting space, and makerspace access free or low-cost for residents, rather than requiring travel to Beckley or further for similar resources. Fayette County is a rural, historically coal-dependent county with limited commercial infrastructure; this project creates local employment and entrepreneurship pathways without requiring residents to relocate or commute for opportunity. The trail-anchored location also means increased foot traffic and visitor spending stays on Main Street rather than bypassing the town, directly benefiting existing and future local businesses along the corridor.

2. What community outcomes will occur if the project is successful? **(200 Words)**

Required

If successful, Mount Hope gains two rehabilitated, fully occupied historic buildings on its main commercial corridor instead of two structures at risk of continued deterioration. The restaurant incubator creates new local jobs and gives a proven local entrepreneur a permanent commercial home, likely spurring additional food and retail interest on the block. The expanded arts center creates a genuine cultural anchor — gallery space that can host rotating regional artists, a conference room available for community and nonprofit use, and makerspace access for residents without their own studio or workshop space. Both outcomes reinforce the Historic Walking Trail as a real visitor destination rather than a route with nothing to stop for, helping Mount Hope capture more of the regional tourism economy the National Park Service has documented. Longer-term, a stabilized, income-generating 708 building demonstrates a replicable model for the town's other vacant historic buildings, and gives H4H a track record that supports future applications for state and federal preservation and revitalization funding.

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3. How will you measure project progress and impact? **(150 Words)**

Required

Progress will be measured through completion of sequenced milestones: survey/replat completion, structural integrity report delivery, funding commitments secured toward the $1.5 million stabilization target, and construction milestones (roof, structural work, interior buildout). Post-completion impact will be measured through occupancy (restaurant incubator lease signed and operating; arts center programming calendar filled), foot traffic on the adjoining trail segment, and gallery/conference room/makerspace usage rates. Financial sustainability will be tracked through incubator rental income and arts center program revenue relative to operating costs.

4. What is the timeline for the project? Please include major phases. **(150 Words)**

Required

Phase 0 (near-term): Survey and replat to separate the privately-owned 706 Main Street parcel from H4H's leasehold, estimated $8,000–$12,000. Phase 1: Structural integrity report on 708 Main Street by New River Engineering, Inc., $40,000, firm estimate — the gating document required before capital investors and lenders can engage. Phase 2: Roof restoration and structural stabilization, estimated $1.5 million, informed by Phase 1 findings. Phase 3: Interior buildout — 704 as storefront gallery, conference room, and makerspace; 708 as restaurant incubator space for its committed first tenant. Phases are sequential by necessity: each unlocks funding and design decisions for the next.

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Criteria 2: Readiness to Proceed

5. What public organization(s) is supporting your application (e.g. municipality, chamber, planning district, nonprofit, etc.)? Is the project part of an existing strategic plan or community planning document? **(150 Words)**

Required

New River Gorge National Park and Preserve has provided a letter of support (June 2026) for H4H's heritage and connectivity work, physically anchored at this same trailhead location. 704 and 708 Main Street sit within the NPS historic district, directly across from Mount Hope City Hall — placing this project at the geographic and civic center of the town's designated redevelopment area not on its periphery. The City of Mount Hope's Comprehensive Plan and Mount Hope Plan 2030 identify Main Street revitalization, historic preservation, and reduced building vacancy as explicit priorities. This project directly executes those stated municipal goals on one of the district's most visible and centrally located properties.

6. How has the community been part of developing a shared vision for this project? How will you continue to engage the community during the training if selected? **(150 Words)**

Required

While no single formal meeting has been held on the 704/708 project specifically, community input has shaped this vision continuously and directly. A PAWV AmeriCorps member completed the predevelopment work on 708 — the architectural engineering report, Phase I ESA, and DEP report — working alongside H4H staff and the community. 704 already functions as lived community space: a resident artist actively uses it as her creative makerspace and gallery today. For 15 years prior to this project, H4H supported a regional community band that brought hundreds of residents through these buildings, generating years of informal feedback about what Mount Hope wants from this space. That accumulated input — creative space, gathering space, food and retail options — directly shaped this proposal's mix of gallery, makerspace, conference room, and restaurant incubator. Ongoing engagement during training would include regular updates through H4H's existing community channels and direct conversations with the resident artist and incoming incubator tenant.

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7. How do you know there is a need and demand for this project from the local community (e.g. market study, feasibility studies, or other evidence)? **(150 Words)**

Required

Demand evidence includes a committed first tenant for the restaurant incubator — a local entrepreneur whose business has withstood three name changes and continuous expansion, evidence of both market viability and entrepreneurial capacity ready to use the space immediately. The absence of any existing commercial kitchen or food-business incubator space in the immediate Mount Hope area is a documented gap. The Mount Hope Comprehensive Plan and Plan 2030 independently identify Main Street vacancy and underused historic buildings as priorities for the town, and NPS's documented $94 million annual gateway-community economic contribution demonstrates a visitor base already present but currently underserved by Main Street commercial offerings.

8. What makes this the right time for your project? What evidence do you have that there is momentum or excitement to get this project done? (e.g. funding commitments, partner agreements, site control, state/local priorities, etc.) **(200 Words)**

Required

Momentum is concrete, not speculative: site control has existed for years via H4H's 50-year lease. Pre-development diligence on 708 is substantially complete — architectural engineering report, Phase I Environmental Site Assessment, and WV DEP report all finished. A firm $40,000 estimate for the remaining structural integrity report is in hand from New River Engineering, Inc. A named, committed tenant is ready to occupy 708 upon completion. NPS has provided a current letter of support connecting this location to an active federal partnership. The financing path is identified, not theoretical: West Virginia and federal historic tax credits (45% combined on qualified rehabilitation costs) paired with SBA 504 debt financing form a realistic capital stack for the $1.5 million stabilization cost, pending the structural report that determines final scope. This is a project ready to move on receipt of the next funding increment, not one still searching for its basic feasibility.

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Criteria 3: Training Fit

10. What are the specific capital improvements you anticipate for this project? (e.g. building renovations, purchasing land, purchasing buildings, purchasing equipment, etc.) **(150 Words)**

Required

Capital improvements include: roof replacement and structural stabilization at 708 Main Street (informed by the pending structural integrity report); interior buildout of 708 into commercial kitchen and restaurant incubator space; interior buildout of 704 into expanded gallery, conference room, and makerspace configurations; and survey/replat work to formalize clean title separating the H4H leasehold from the adjacent privately-owned parcel. No land purchase is required — the buildings are already under a 50-year lease.

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11. What earned income opportunities do you expect as a result of the project? What other types of funding are you willing to explore? (e.g., debts/loans: banks/financial institutions, community development financial institutions, foundations, government; equity: low-income housing tax credits, new markets tax credits, historic tax credits; grants: individuals, corporations, foundations, government) **(150 Words)**

Required

Earned income opportunities include restaurant incubator lease/rental income from 708, gallery sales commission, conference room rental fees, and makerspace membership or usage fees at 704. Regarding funding: H4H is open to historic tax credit equity (WV and federal, 45% combined potential on qualified rehabilitation costs), SBA 504 debt financing, CDFI loans, and grants from foundations and government sources. Given H4H's limited existing cash reserves, grant and equity sources are the near-term priority over debt, with SBA 504 anticipated for the stabilization phase once tax credit equity and grant funding are secured.

12. Why are you interested in this training? How could you see yourself using this training beyond the project you work on during the course? What is your current level of knowledge about community development finance and how to access different types of investments (e.g., loans, tax credits, etc.) **(200 Words)**

Required

This training is of direct interest because the 704/708 project has reached the point where continued progress depends on navigating capital stacks — historic tax credits, SBA lending, and investor-ready pitch materials — that fall outside day-to-day nonprofit grant-writing experience. Current knowledge of community development finance comes primarily from prior research into historic tax credit mechanics and SBA 504 as a financing vehicle, but not from direct transaction experience structuring a stack of this size. Beyond this specific project, the training would build capacity to pursue historic preservation and revitalization work across H4H's other Mount Hope properties and to support other rural West Virginia organizations navigating similar capital access barriers.

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14. How can you help build the capacity of your community by participating in this training? **(150 Words)**

Required

Participation would build lasting local capacity: skills in structuring historic tax credit and SBA financing transferable to other Mount Hope buildings beyond 704/708, a stronger pitch and funder-relations skill set applicable to H4H's broader grant portfolio, and direct connections to regional capital providers that could benefit other Fayette County revitalization efforts beyond this single project. As Executive Director of the only organization actively stewarding Mount Hope's historic Main Street buildings, capacity gained here compounds across future projects rather than being tied to this one building alone.

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Additional Questions

Required 1. **If employed, is your employer supportive of your participation in the training?**

Yes

Required 2. **Please upload <u>one</u> letter of support from a community-based partner that is NOT your employer.**

3. **Please upload any strategic planning documents that demonstrate the need and/or include the proposed project as part of the solution. (This could include things like a community development plan, economic development plan, Main Street revitalization plan, community health needs assessment, etc.)**

Required 4. **Virtual training sessions will be held weekly from 2-4 p.m. ET on Mondays. The training will run from January to May, 2027. Attending with your camera on and actively participating in each session is required. You are allowed two absences during the training but must view the recording and complete the homework. All participants must complete the pitch session. Will you be able to meet these requirements?**

Yes

Required 5. **How did you hear about this training? (Who and organization if applicable)**

WV Community Development Hub - Emm

**Optional upload: Readiness matrix/checklist*